

Sweden Says 'Hej då' to Phones in Class!

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Have you ever tried to do homework while your phone buzzes with **notifications**? It's super hard to focus! Sweden thinks so too. Starting this fall, the country will ban mobile phones in all schools. That means no phones during class at all. Sweden used to be a champion of **digital learning**. It's home to Spotify and Ericsson, and its schools are packed with laptops and tablets. But now the government is hitting the rewind button. Why? Because reading levels are dropping. In a big international test, almost one in four Swedish 9th graders couldn't read well enough. The government believes books and pencils are better for learning. They even set aside \$59 million to buy new textbooks. At Malmö Borgarskola high school, phones are already banned. Students drop them in a box called the '**Mobile Hotel**' and pick them up after class. 'When you have a phone, there's always something to look at,' says Melina, 17. 'It's less of a **distraction**.' Her classmate Vasilije agrees: 'Games are more fun than learning, so taking away phones helps.' But not everyone is happy. Some experts worry that kids won't learn **digital skills** they'll need for future jobs. Still, Sweden is also telling parents to have **screen-free** zones at home. Even little kids under 2 should only use books and non-digital toys. It's a big experiment will going old-school make kids smarter? We'll find out!

Word Treasure

notifications -- Alerts that pop up on a phone screen, like a new message or game update.

digital learning -- Using computers, tablets, and online programs for education.

Mobile Hotel -- A box where students put their phones during class so they aren't distracted.

distraction -- Something that takes your attention away from what you should be doing.

digital skills -- The ability to use computers, software, and the internet for different tasks.

screen-free -- Having no screens like phones, tablets, or TVs in a place or time.

Background you need

Sweden (a country in Northern Europe) is famous for its tech companies like Spotify (a music app) and Ericsson (a maker of mobile technology). In the past, Sweden pushed for lots of computers in classrooms.

Now many countries are wondering if too much screen time harms learning. Studies show that reading books on paper helps kids remember better than reading on screens.

Break it down

WHO: Sweden's government, students like Melina and Vasilije, and school Malmö Borgarskola.

WHAT: A ban on mobile phones during all classes, plus money to buy new textbooks instead.

WHERE: Throughout Sweden, including high schools that already use 'Mobile Hotel' boxes.

WHY: Reading levels are dropping -- nearly 1 in 4 ninth graders couldn't read well enough -- and officials believe phones are a big distraction.

Why it matters

This story may make you think about how you use your own phone or tablet during homework time, and why sometimes putting devices away can help your brain focus better.

Test what you remember

1. What is Sweden banning in all schools starting this fall?
 - (A) Laptops
 - (B) Textbooks
 - (C) Mobile phones
 - (D) Backpacks
2. What did the government set aside \$59 million to buy?
 - (A) New tablets
 - (B) New textbooks
 - (C) New phones
 - (D) New laptops
3. What is the 'Mobile Hotel' at Malmö Borgarskola high school?
 - (A) A store that sells phones
 - (B) A box for storing phones during class
 - (C) A hotel for travelers
 - (D) A new educational app
4. According to student Melina, why is not having a phone good?
 - (A) It saves battery life
 - (B) It's less of a distraction
 - (C) She can talk to friends more
 - (D) It makes the phone cheaper
5. What concern do some experts have about the phone ban?
 - (A) Kids will read too many books
 - (B) Kids won't learn digital skills
 - (C) Phones will break more often
 - (D) Schools will lose extra money
6. What does Sweden suggest for children under 2 years old?
 - (A) Use only tablets for learning
 - (B) Use only books and non-digital toys
 - (C) Watch educational videos daily
 - (D) Play outside three hours a day

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

- 1. Better concentration:** Many students and teachers feel the ban will help everyone concentrate better and improve reading skills.
- 2. Missing future skills:** Some tech experts worry that kids won't be prepared for a digital future if they don't learn to use technology responsibly in school.
- 3. Finding balance:** The experiment shows how societies are trying to balance the benefits of technology with the need for deep, focused learning.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):